



THE SHIV SENA'S SADA SARVANKAR HAS REBELLED AGAINST THE PARTY

this and neither was I offered any explanation. So I decided to enter the political fray as an independent," says Khanvilkar. While the NCP may be pleased to see the Congress face the heat from some of its independent stalwarts, the party itself is a victim of rebellion. There are several constituencies where NCP candidates are faced with the prospects of rebel candidates from their own party. In Radhanagari constituency, four NCP rebels are contesting against party nominee and sitting MLA K.P. Patil. In all, a staggering 1,820 independents are contesting the 288 constituencies.

The hunger for power has set a new precedent for parties. They can no longer take their workers for granted, nor their commitment. While the rebellion phenomenon is more rampant in the Congress-NCP combine, the saffron alliance is not

without its share of rebelling candidates. Party veteran Vinay Natu's family has been a household name in the Guhagar constituency of Ratnagari district since 1972. Despite this, the local favourite has been sidelined in favour of Shiv Sena's Ramdas Kadam, all towards "the politics of alliance". BJP spokesperson Madhav Bhandari says, "Natu's seat had to be compromised for a poll alliance with the Shiv Sena. It is the only serious case of rebellion in the BJP because of which we will be impacted."

But the so-called alliance politics has taken its toll where it's likely to hurt parties the most. Whether it is Natu—who says the party gave him clearance to begin campaigning and ultimately gave the ticket to Kadam—or Sarvankar, a Shiv Sainik of 30 years and sitting MLA from the Mahim constituency, the breach of trust by the party high command is the larger issue for most rebels. Sarvankar says, "Nobody ever told

DESHMUKH DID NOT LET HIS MINISTERIAL STATUS DETER HIM FROM turning rebel. Denied a ticket by the Congress, he is fighting as an independent against Rajendra Shekhawat, Pratibha Patil's son.



SUNIL
DESHMUKH

FOTOCORP



RAJENDRA
SHEKHAWAT

me about the development. If I had been informed it would have been better but I was asked to work on the constituency and assumed that I would get a ticket. I was trapped in a situation that the leaders themselves advised me to create. After giving my life to the Shiv Sena, I feel shocked and cheated." Within hours, a hurt Sarvankar fell into the arms of Congress, which has decided to give him a ticket from his erstwhile constituency. Sarvankar claims that the Congress offered him the ticket as the party wants to break into the Sena bastion and attempt to win a seat that has not been theirs for 20 years. The outcome of this rebel rousing will surely impact the results. More independents mean many more egos to pander to, in case their help is needed to form the government. ■